FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

India's tragedy is that its genius is so often misdirected towards unethical jugaad. Our examination system for higher education and recruitment keeps supplying us with dismal proof of that. Its history often seems to be a string of episodes in a long-running series of swindles and snafus. But in 2024, even that paled as the Exam Scandal struck like a tornado. It started with the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate) or NEET-UG, the single door to all of India's medical colleges. On May 5, over 2.3 million unsuspecting students appeared for the test at 4,750 centres across 571 cities in India and 14 abroad. The results came on June 4, the same day the election results were out, so it took time for the reported oddities to catch everyone's attention. But soon, serious questions began to be asked about the unusual number of perfect and near-perfect scores and other distortions. It became a full-blown inaugural controversy for Modi 3.0, as three more exams were caught up in the maelstrom. First, UGC-NET, the national eligibility test conducted by the University Grants Commission for PhDs, junior research fellowships and assistant professorships, was cancelled within a day of it being held on June 18. Then, a similar set of exams for science graduates, the CSIR-UGC-NET, was deferred on June 21—four days before it was to kick off. Finally, NEET-PG, the entrance gate for postgraduate medical studies conducted by the National Board of Examinations scheduled for June 23, was postponed on its eve.



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At the centre of the exam mess is a body created in 2017 precisely to streamline and modernise the conduct of India's common entrance examinations, the National Testing Agency (NTA). The cure, at first glance, seems to have itself been struck by the disease. In just these four exams conducted over May-June, more than 3.6 million students have been put to trauma; include their parents and we are talking upwards of 10 million Indians. So it is good that the government is trying to come up with repair work that's both urgent and durable while it puts out the fire on all sides. The Opposition, which has put on some muscle these days, is seeking to throw the regime onto the mat with the controversy. But with the future of India's young at stake, all cool heads must come together for this exercise.

There's an old rhetorical question that goes, "Who'll police the police?" In this issue, we give you exhaustive reportage but go beyond that to "examine the examination" system in its entirety. The forensic audit must, of course, centre around the NTA. In charge of about 15 entrance and fellowship examinations, it handled 12.3 million individual exam-givers in 2023. That made it the second-largest exam-conducting agency in the world, after China's Gaokao—which handled 12.9 million exam-takers last year. As Executive Editor Kaushik Deka explains in our cover story, a scan of the NTA's seemingly tamper-proof process for NEET-UG reveals 11 points of vulnerability where a human element is involved. This covers the entire life cycle of the question paper, from the time it's set by subject experts; to its storage and transport before, during and after printing; to the time the OMR or optical answer sheets are collected after the exam. The leak alleged to have taken place in the NEET-UG exam could have happened at any of those points. NEET-UG is conducted in pen-and-paper mode, so that unequal digital access does not disadvantage any aspirant.

There were several other red flags—nothing to do with technology. Registration was extended twice after the month-long window had closed. Some toppers, it turned out, had registered during this extra time. Equally curiously, the results date was advanced from June 14 to June 4, perhaps a day chosen precisely to divert attention from the expected irregularities. Six 'toppers' were from one exam centre in Bahadurgarh, Haryana—they had seat numbers in the same sequence, and had not done particularly great in their Class 12 boards. Also in question was the 'arbitrary' award of grace marks to 1,563 students, later cancelled after judicial challenge.

Clearly, the system is in need of a total reset. And things are moving in that direction along several planes. After weeks of denialism, the Centre has got the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to take over the NEET paper leak probe, initiated originally by the Economic Offences Unit of the Bihar Police. At another level, a seven-member committee appointed by the education ministry has started looking at three key areas related to entrance exams. Headed by Dr K. Radhakrishnan, former chairman of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), and with a mix of eminent academics, top bureaucrats and government representatives, the panel will suggest ways to create a zero-error exam process, beef up the data security protocol around it and, over and above everything, examine the structure and functioning of the NTA.

The NTA was not brought into being as a statutory body through an Act of Parliament, as originally envisaged. An autonomous society under the Societies Registration Act, it receives funds from the government and functions under the education ministry's oversight. It's modelled on an American prototype: the Educational Testing Service (ETS), which conducts the famous SAT, GRE and TOEFL exams without a glitch the world over. But the ETS has over 200 permanent staff members; the NTA operates with just over two dozen. It mostly relies on government officials on deputation and temporary employees. This severe understaffing means the agency has to outsource critical functions such as paper-setting, distribution and data security. A clear path for reform may come when the Radhakrishnan committee submits its report in two months. In an interview to INDIA TODAY, education minister Dharmendra Pradhan says, "There is no shortcut, we need to make things hundred per cent foolproof. Our government is committed to zero error."

The Supreme Court, too, is hearing a bunch of petitions in the NEET case. The next hearing is on July 8. The very architecture of the NEET exam has come in for a lot of criticism in the one decade of its life, with the SC quashing it as "unconstitutional" right after its birth in 2013. Its legal restoration in 2016 has not put to rest all questions, including many from the southern states. Expect some fundamental issues to be revisited. Our cover story, meanwhile, proposes ways to solve India's exam mess—looking at best practices globally. It is essential for India to have a fair, transparent and well-regulated examination system in which all the stakeholders have faith in order for us to have a quality education system. An absolute must for a Viksit Bharat.

(Aroon Purie)